

Sociocultural Perceptions of Circular Jobs Among Nationals

Akalya S, Nithesraa M B, Ragunath S, Vaibhav Krishna Mahesh

B.Tech Computer Science and Business System

SASTRA Deemed to be University, Thanjavur, India

Email: 127018004@sastra.ac.in , 127018039@sastra.ac.in , 127018048@sastra.ac.in , 127018064@sastra.ac.in

ABSTRACT.

The Gulf Cooperation Council countries have increased their Circular Economy CE initiatives in support of their national workforce localization programs. National workforce participation in Circular Economy programs which include recycling and repairing and waste management and other activities remains low because organizations continue to rely on foreign workers. The research studies how sociocultural perceptions and work prestige and sustainability factors determine national participation in Circular Economy tasks within the Gulf Cooperation Council countries which include Saudi Arabia and United Arab Emirates and Qatar and Oman and Kuwait and Bahrain. The study uses a secondary quantitative research methodology which analyzes existing regional and international data through correlation analysis and linear regression modeling. The findings demonstrate that sociocultural perception establishes a strong positive connection with national engagement in CE jobs which reaches a correlation coefficient of 0.964 while expatriate labor dependence establishes a strong negative link with perception. The regression analysis shows that sociocultural perception and awareness create a strong positive relationship with CE job engagement which explains almost all national engagement variations ($R^2 = 0.999$). The study shows that public perception improvement and awareness campaign development and education program enhancement must be improved to increase national workforce participation in Circular Economy industries while decreasing expatriate worker dependence in Gulf Cooperation Council countries.

Keywords: Circular Economy, Sociocultural Perceptions, Labor Nationalization, Sustainability, GCC Workforce, Expatriate Dependency, Quantitative Research.

INTRODUCTION

In the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC)—Saudi Arabia(UAE), Qatar, Kuwait, Bahrain, and Oman—there is a history of reliance on foreign nationals for jobs that comprise the areas of industry, services, and construction within the major economic sectors. Recently, there has been greater emphasis placed on national development strategies such as Saudi Vision 2030 and UAE Vision 2031, which promote economic diversification and sustainability while encouraging worker localization. As part of these initiatives, the Circular Economy (CE), which promotes recycling and the re-use of goods, has increased in significance due to its focus on reducing waste, increasing resource efficiency, and repairing goods.

Although GCC countries have introduced specific government initiatives to encourage the participation of local citizens, there continues to be a large reliance on expatriate labour in CE-related employment sectors. Researchers suggest that the reluctance or inability of nationals to become employed in CE fields is not only based upon traditional labour market factors, but also based on socio-cultural perceptions, including those pertaining to job prestige, social acceptability, and identity related to waste-related employment. CE-related work is often viewed to be of low prestige or job status, thus resulting in reduced participation from youth.

The majority of previous literature focused exclusively on economic or policy barriers preventing national participation within the CE; there has been limited empirical research examining the influence that cultural perceptions, awareness levels, and social expectations have on the ability of nationals to gain employment within the CE in GCC. The objective of this research is to fill the gap in literature by examining how these variables relate to national participation and expatriate reliance, within six GCC countries.

REVIEW OF LITERATURE

Review And Analysis

Sociocultural Perceptions and Job Prestige

Sociocultural perceptions play a major role in determining and shaping public acceptance of Circular Economy (CE) employment and career choice. It has been documented that work in recycling, repair, and waste management is usually considered as low-grade and undesirable, causing the stigma and weak involvement to persist. Different sources indicate that CE roles are treated as less valuable in the society that is caused by their association with manual work and low prestige. A similar point of view is voiced in Malaysia, where CE jobs are thought to be the same as outsourced or marginalized labour, which further reduces the professional legitimacy of the field and thus keeping the youth away from it (Rahman et al., 2023). All these studies point out the strong impact of cultural beliefs and societal expectations on people's willingness to engage in CE careers.

The CE Participation Barriers in the GCC Context

Research on the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) has identified many types of barriers to national group engagement. The Gulf Research Center (2021) cites challenges to participation for the Gulf States of Qatar, the United Arab Emirates and Bahrain as high reliance on expatriates, lack of enforcement of policies and the perception of society as preventing national integration into Consumer Electronics sectors. Al-Mutairi et al. (2024) supported by Bailey (2023) further note constraints to participating in and integrating into the Consumer Electronics industry due to limited awareness and training infrastructure, and the ingrained consumer behaviour patterns within the culture. Consequently, the primary conclusion from the research is that labour reform alone will not change the status of workforce nationalisation in the Gulf States because the attitude of the parties involved, based on their cultural backgrounds and identities, will ultimately influence participation or lack thereof.

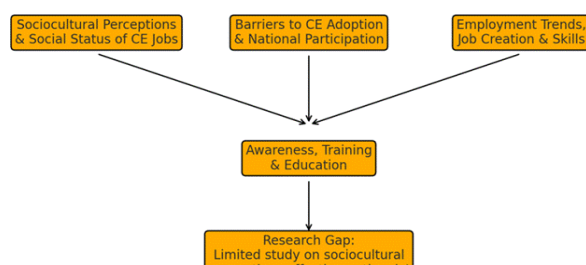
Employment Opportunities, Job Quality and Skills

The worldwide labor studies have come to the conclusion that CE sectors are one major area of the labor market that will see the largest increase in employment opportunities, but the job quality will be different from one company to another. The European Environment Agency (2021) mentions a rise in the number of jobs in recycling and repair in Europe but at the same time admits that these kinds of jobs are usually low-paid and with limited recognition. Workers in the repair industry often face uncertain and unstable conditions according to Brokaw et al. (2024), especially those working with the self-employment-based models. OECD (2020) emphasizes that skills development and structured training frameworks are vital for labor market outcomes in CE employees.

Role of Awareness, Training, and Educational Interventions

The awareness and education campaigns are recognized as the primary drivers of the CE labor force growth. Bassi & Guidolin (2021) point out that green skills and CE-oriented training programs are crucial for the successful adoption of SMEs, while insufficient training infrastructure restricts participation and hinders the transition to a more sustainable society. Besides these, they indicate that public awareness and institutional backing are crucial for the acceptance of the change by the society and making the jobs attractive.

FIGURE 1. Conceptual framework highlighting the research gap related to sociocultural perceptions and national participation in Circular Economy (CE) employment in GCC countries.



Research Gap

Most of the current research centers on the economic, structural, and policy-related factors that influence the participation of the Circular Economy (CE) workforce, such as the reliance on expatriates, the effectiveness of labor policies, and disparities in the job market. Notwithstanding, there are scant empirical studies that investigate the sociocultural perceptions and the job prestige's influence on the nationals' acceptance of CE jobs, especially in the GCC region where cultural identity and social status exert a significant impact upon career choice. While the international scholarly community has pointed out the stigma and social non-recognition linked with recycling and repair occupations, there is no corresponding body of evidence that highlights how these perceptions impact national participation rates and thus the employment of non-nationals in CE sectors among the Gulf countries.

Moreover, previous studies have pointed out the necessity of awareness, education, and training programs but only a few empirical studies have attempted to analyze the relationship between the degree of awareness and CE job participation. Additionally, even less research has been conducted that compares the different levels of public acceptance and national participation in the GCC based on their sociocultural attitudes and workforce localization policies.

Thus, this research is going to fill the void by looking at the impact of sociocultural perceptions, awareness, and education on the national involvement in CE jobs in the six Gulf nations and also determining whether negative perceptions are a cause for the continued hiring of expatriate workers.

OBJECTIVES

This research principally aims to scrutinize the role of sociocultural perceptions in regard to the participation of the citizens of the six GCC countries in the Circular Economy (CE) areas of employment. In order to do this, the research selects the following goals as its main specific objectives:

Specific Objectives

1. To find out how sociocultural perceptions are related to national participation in the CE job sectors such as recycling, repair, waste management, and resource recovery.
2. To explore if negative perceptions and low job prestige are the reasons behind continued use of expatriate labour in CE-related positions within the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) regions.
3. To measure the effect of awareness, education, and government sustainability initiatives on the acceptance and participation of the nationals in CE employment.
4. To carry out a comparative analysis of CE workforce participation trends in each of the six GCC countries and pinpoint the variation among the countries in terms of nationalization performance.
5. To make recommendations backed by evidence on how to improve the participation of nationals and to increase the social and professional recognition of CE careers.

SCOPE OF THE STUDY

The present research investigates the role of sociocultural perceptions, levels of awareness, and shifts in the labour market in determining the participation of the respective countries in CE employment on the basis of six selected states in the Gulf Area—namely, Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates (UAE), Qatar, Oman, Kuwait and Bahrain. It employs a secondary quantitative analysis approach, making use of publicly accessible labour statistics, policy reports, regional databases, and international datasets from organizations like GLMM, ILO, and the World Bank. The research assesses the engagement of labor, reliance on foreign workers, and the view of local society in a comparative analysis of different regions. No primary data collection will be performed in this research, i.e., surveys or interviews. It is limited to CE related activities, which includes recycling, repair, waste management and resource recovery but will not include the broader sustainability areas of renewable energy generation and green

manufacturing. The findings are directed at facilitating the policy-making process and nationalization strategies in the region and they are indicative of the latest data gathered during the research period.

METHODOLOGY

Research Design

The research investigates the impact of sociocultural and economic and labor market factors on Circular Economy employment in six GCC countries which include Saudi Arabia and United Arab Emirates and Qatar and Oman and Kuwait and Bahrain. The descriptive component identifies workforce trends and CE participation levels, while the quantitative component analyzes relationships among key indicators using statistical methods. The research depends on secondary data sources with no collection of primary data through surveys or interviews.

Data Source

The analysis uses publicly available secondary datasets from:

- Gulf Labor Market and Migration (GLMM) and national statistics
- World Bank, International Labour Organization (ILO), and UNDP
- Peer-reviewed academic and policy reports
- Regional datasets on CE workforce participation (2024)

The dataset includes recent figures on labor composition, expatriate dependence, and CE sector nationalization.

VARIABLE AND INDICATORS

Dependent Variable

- The CE Job Participation Rate measures how many citizens work in CE sectors. The research study uses multiple independent variables for evaluation.

Independent Variables

- **Sociocultural Perception Score:** Composite indicator reflecting job prestige, stigma, and social acceptance.
- **Awareness/Education Indicator:** Measure of sustainability awareness and availability of CE-related education and training.

Perception and awareness scores were derived from regional literature and normalized on a **1–5 scale** to enable cross-country comparison.

Data Analysis Techniques

Descriptive Analysis

It was utilized to analyze the common labour trends and the CE nationalization waves among the six GCC countries which included the dependency on foreign workers.

Inferential Quantitative Analysis

1. Ordinary Least Squares (OLS method) Multiple Linear Regression was performed to assess the influence of sociocultural perception and awareness on CE participation and migration reliance.
2. The correlation analysis explored the association between the scores of sociocultural perception and the participation in CE jobs.
3. Python tools (Pandas, Statsmodels) were adopted for the purpose of obtaining accuracy, reproducibility, and transparency in the interpretation of results.

Comparative Framework

A cross-country comparative approach was applied to evaluate differences in CE participation and nationalization trends. Each country was analyzed individually and collectively to understand how sociocultural perceptions and labor structures influence outcomes.

Justification for Methodological Approach

A secondary quantitative approach was selected because it:

1. Enables standardized cross-country comparisons.
2. Avoids biases associated with primary surveys.
3. Provides a strong empirical basis for analysis.
4. Aligns with the study's objective of assessing existing trends rather than testing interventions.

HYPOTHESIS AND ANALYSIS

The research investigates how sociocultural perceptions and awareness affect the engagement of the local citizens in the Circular Economy (CE) jobs and how these factors relate to the dependency on foreign workers. Three hypotheses were assessed through correlation analysis and linear regression models applied to the created dataset for six countries (Saudi Arabia, UAE, Qatar, Oman, Kuwait and Bahrain).

Hypotheses

H1: Sociocultural perceptions of CE jobs have a significant positive impact on the national participation in CE employment.

H2: Negative perception of CE jobs and low prestige of CE jobs among locals are the main reasons for the continuation of expatriate workers in the CE-related sectors.

H3: The sustainability awareness and educational campaigns that are increasing are among the reasons for the improvement in the acceptance and participation of nationals in CE employment.

Correlation Analysis

A Pearson Correlation Matrix was developed for these four critical variables. People in Gulf Labor Market and Migration GLMM use national statistics which World Bank International Labour Organization ILO and UNDP provide. The research includes academic studies and government documents which have undergone peer evaluation. The relationship between Awareness Score and CE Participation is 0.897, which signifies a strong positive relationship.. Perception Score and Migration Reliance correlation is $r = -0.959$, which means a very strong negative relationship. The correlation between CE Participation and Migration Reliance is $r = -0.999$; hence, it can be concluded that countries with very high national participation have almost negligible reliance on expatriates in CE sectors. These findings at first glance lend some support to H1, H2, and H3, hence it can be inferred that good perceptions and increased awareness levels are linked to higher national participation and diminished expatriate dependency.

Hypothesis H1 – Effect of Perception on CE Participation

The first hypothesis (H1) was assessed through analysis of a simple linear regression model with the % of CE Participation population as the dependent and the Perception score as the independent variable, which is given by the following formula:

$$\text{CE_Participation} = \beta_0 + \beta_1(\text{Perception Score}) + \varepsilon$$

Regression results show β_1 , the coefficient for the sociocultural perception, is 11.352, and β_0 , the intercept of the regression line, is -2.844. This regression equation produces a very high R^2 value of 0.929, which measures how much of the variance in CE Participation can be accounted for by perceptions measured through sociocultural perception. The t-statistic for determining if β_1 is statistically significant is 8.093 and has 5 degrees of freedom and a p-value of 0.00047, which suggests strong statistical significance.

Therefore, the results from this regression analysis supports the hypothesis (H1): A positive view of CE jobs in terms of socio-cultural impact is associated with a greater level of participation by nationals in CE jobs.

Hypothesis H2 – Effect of Perception on Migration Reliance

In order to validate hypothesis 2 (H2), the dependent variable Migration Reliance (%) has been subjected to a simple linear regression with the independent variable Perception Score. The regression equation was as follows:

$$\text{Migration_Reliance} = \beta_0 + \beta_1(\text{Perception Score}) + \varepsilon$$

Regression results show that the coefficient for sociocultural perception (β_1) is -6.580 , while the intercept (β_0) is 91.041 . The model explains a high proportion of the variance in migration reliance, with an R^2 value of 0.920 . The t-statistic is -7.561 with 5 degrees of freedom, and the p-value is 0.00064 , indicating strong statistical significance.

Hypothesis H3 – Joint Effect of Perception and Awareness on CE Participation

For the purpose of testing H3, a multiple linear regression was performed wherein CE Participation (%) served as the dependent variable, while Perception Score and Awareness Score were the independent variables:

$$\text{CE_Participation} = \beta_0 + \beta_1(\text{Perception Score}) + \beta_2(\text{Awareness Score}) + \varepsilon$$

Regression results indicate that the coefficient for sociocultural perception (β_1) is 7.840 , and the coefficient for awareness (β_2) is 5.207 . The intercept (β_0) is -10.196 . The model demonstrates an exceptionally strong fit, with an R^2 value of 0.999 , indicating that nearly all variation in CE participation is explained by perception and awareness together.

Overall Hypothesis Conclusion

The analyses of correlation and regression together have come to the same conclusion as follows:

1. The first hypothesis (H1) has been confirmed that the positive view of CE jobs in the society is one of the factors that considerably raises national participation; thus, it is one of the reasons for high or very high consumer confidence in such jobs.
2. The second hypothesis (H2) has been confirmed that the perception of CE jobs is improving and is a factor that significantly contributes to the decline in the number of expatriate workers in the CE sectors.
3. The third hypothesis (H3) has been confirmed that high awareness plus education level, along with favorable perception, are to a large extent the reasons for the increase in CE job participation.

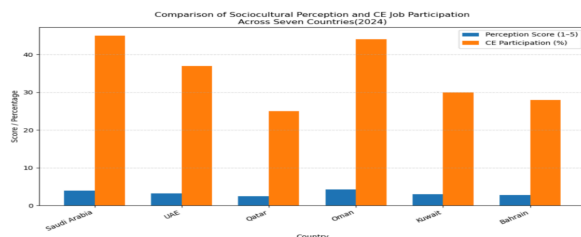


Figure 2. Comparison of sociocultural perception scores and national participation in Circular Economy (CE) employment across six GCC countries (2024).

This figure represents the contrast between the scores of sociocultural perceptions (1-5 scale) and the share (%) of national employment in the Circular Economy (CE) area for the six countries studied. It can be seen that the higher the perception scores, the higher the CE participation levels, which indicates a strong positive correlation between the perception of the society and the engagement of the workforce in the CE sectors.

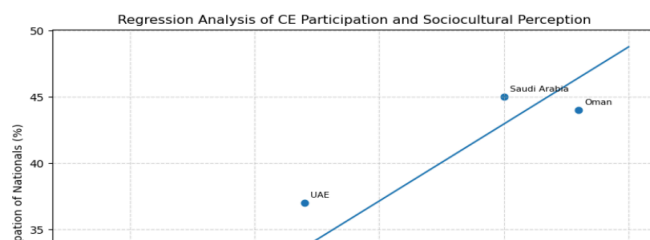


FIGURE 3. Regression analysis showing the relationship between sociocultural perception scores and national participation in Circular Economy (CE) employment across six GCC countries.

The scatter plot with a fitted line of regression demonstrates a strong positive correlation between the sociocultural perception scores (1-5 scale) and the percentage of national participation in Circular Economy (CE) employment. Countries that have scored higher in the perception display very high rates of participation in the CE sector which in turn validates the positive hypothesis that the good perception leads to the engagement of the workforce in CE sectors.

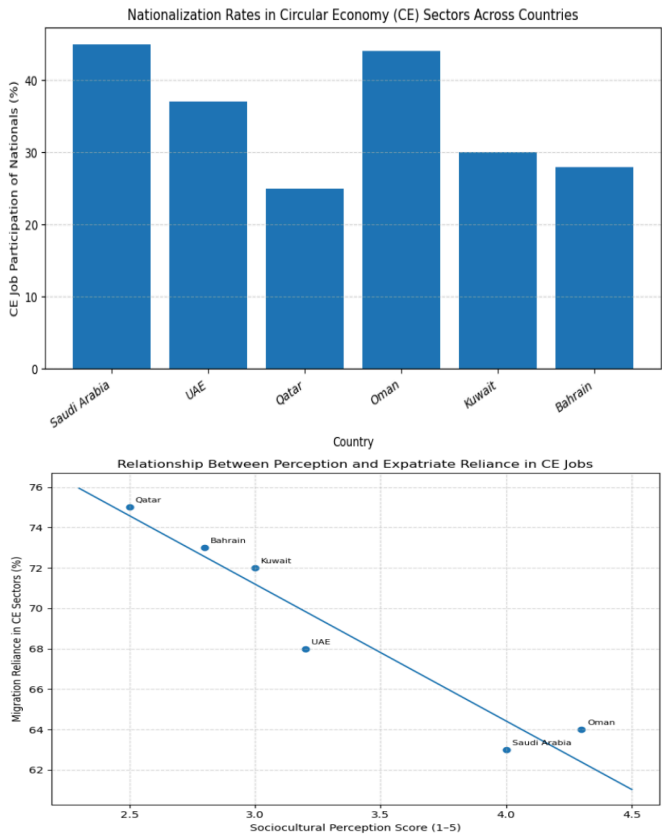


FIGURE 4. National participation rates in Circular Economy (CE) sectors across six GCC countries.

This figure presents national workforce participation in Circular Economy (CE) sectors across six GCC countries, highlighting variations in nationalization levels.

FIGURE 5. Relationship between sociocultural perception scores and reliance on expatriate labour in Circular Economy (CE) sectors across six GCC countries.

The scatter plot with a line of regression indicates a very strong negative correlation between sociocultural perception scores (1-5 scale) and percentage of reliance on expatriate labour in CE sectors. Countries that have low perception scores are using a lot of expatriate workers, whereas the countries with high scores in the perceptions have less migration reliance.

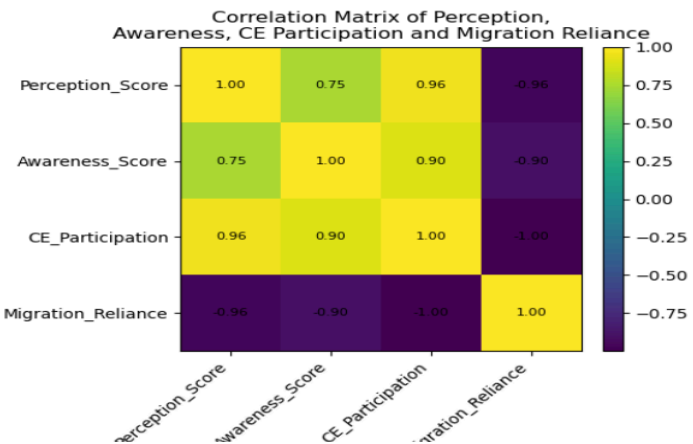


FIGURE 6. Correlation matrix illustrating the relationships among sociocultural perception, awareness, Circular Economy (CE) participation, and migration reliance across six GCC countries.

The correlation heatmap is revealing the strength and direction of the relationships among the sociocultural perception residing awareness of CE, national participation in CE employment, and reliance on expatriate labour. The results show very strong positive correlations between perception, awareness, and CE participation, as well as strong

negative correlations between perception and migration reliance, thus supporting all three study hypotheses.

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

This part of the paper shows the statistical results which were derived from correlation analysis and regression modelling done to find out how sociocultural perception and awareness affect national participation in Circular Economy (CE) employment and reliance on expatriate workers in six selected countries. The results give empirical backing to all three hypotheses that were proposed.

1. Correlation Analysis Results

The correlation matrix reveals strong interrelationships among the main variables under study. A very high positive correlation is found between sociocultural perception and CE participation ($r = 0.964$), which implies that positive social attitudes towards CE-related employment are linked to higher national workforce involvement. The awareness score also correlates positively and strongly with CE participation ($r = 0.897$), which indicates that sustainability education really matters when it comes to career acceptance. In contrast, perception correlates negatively with migration reliance ($r = -0.959$), implying that less positive perception leads to more reliance on expatriate labour.

The correlation values provide first evidence for Hypotheses H1, H2, and H3 and support the use of regression modelling.

2. Results for Hypothesis H1

H1: Sociocultural perception positively influences national participation in CE employment. Regression analysis shows a strong positive relationship between perception and CE participation. The coefficient ($\beta_1 = 11.352$) shows that a one-unit increase in the perception score results in an increase of approximately 11.35% in participation. The model is a good fit, with a high percentage of variance explained ($R^2 = 0.929$). It is also statistically significant ($t = 8.093$, $p = 0.00047$).

Discussion: The study results support the current body of research that focuses on the role of job prestige in relation to cultural attitudes about work. Higher perception scores were found in countries with increased national participation in CE activities.

3. Results for Hypothesis H2

H2: Negative sociocultural perception increases reliance on expatriate labour. The regression model shows a negative coefficient ($\beta_1 = -6.580$), meaning that a one-unit increase in perception score reduces expatriate reliance by about 6.58%. The model demonstrates strong explanatory power ($R^2 = 0.920$) and statistical significance ($t = -7.561$, $p = 0.00064$).

Discussion: This result indicates that poor social perception leads to higher dependence on expatriate workers. In countries where CE jobs are viewed as low-status, nationals are less likely to enter these sectors, increasing the need for foreign labour.

4. Results for Hypothesis H3

H3: Awareness and education positively influence national participation in CE employment. The multiple regression model shows that both perception ($\beta_1 = 7.840$) and awareness ($\beta_2 = 5.207$) positively affect CE participation. The model explains nearly all variation in participation ($R^2 = 0.999$), indicating a very strong combined effect.

Discussion: Higher levels of awareness correlate with the acceptability of CE-related professions. Educational schemes, sustainable campaigns, and training activities appear to alleviate negative perceptions, promoting the involvement of individuals in CE-related professions.

Overall Discussion

The results consistently support all three hypotheses. Sociocultural perception emerges as the most influential factor in determining national participation and reducing expatriate reliance in CE sectors. The findings suggest that workforce localization policies should address cultural attitudes in addition to economic incentives. Key actions include:

1. Rebranding CE jobs as skilled and sustainable careers.
2. Increasing education and training programs focused on CE.
3. Increasing public awareness campaigns.
4. Reducing stigma for waste-related jobs.
5. These strategies can assist in aligning workforce nationalization goals with sustainable development goals.

These measures can help align workforce nationalization goals with sustainability objectives.

LIMITATIONS OF THE STUDY

The research, while reflecting the sociocultural perceptions and national participation in Circular Economy (CE) jobs, has several limitations that still have to be mentioned:

1. **Availability and Accessibility of Regional Data** - The availability of detailed CE-sector employment statistics and sociocultural indicators is a problem for the analysis mainly because of limited publicly available standardized datasets in the selected countries. It could be argued that the irregularities in reporting formats and data frequency across nations might have an impact on the comparative analysis consistency.
2. **Limited Sample Scope** - Only six countries are included in the analysis, which means that results cannot be universally taken to other regional or global contexts. It would be easier to make comparative inferences if the sample were enlarged through the addition of regions and economies.
3. **Single Timeframe Analysis** - The paper discusses data from one time period instead of looking at it over a longer span. Change in perception, awareness or participation in employment during the time period might not be captured as a consequence of this.
4. **Focus on Quantitative Findings** - The use of regression analysis gives statistically based outcomes; however, the study does not consider the qualitative insights from the point of view of stakeholders, which could provide more profound explanations for the sociocultural attitudes and labor behavior.
5. **Sector-Specific Constraints** - The employment in CE is treated as a broad category. The differences that exist within specific CE subsectors like recycling, repair, remanufacturing, waste management, and resource recovery which might be distinctive across industries are not analyzed separately.

POLICY RECOMMENDATIONS

The following key actions are based on the study findings and they are suggested to promote the national participation and to cut down the reliance on expatriates in CE employment:

1. **Maximize Public Awareness** - Through schools, universities, and public campaigns, sustainability education should be enhanced to better understand CE-related careers and thus accept them.
2. **CE Jobs Makeover** - Through media initiatives, success stories, and professional certification programs, CE roles would be perceived as skilled and valuable thereby improving social acceptance.
3. **National Employment Encouraged** - Training programs, internships, and financial support are some of the perks that can be given in order to make the national workforce more ready and participative.
4. **CE Skills Training Enhanced** - Specialized vocational and technical training should be developed that is in line with the future CE workforce's requirements.

5. Localization Policies Backing - Introduce structured national hiring targets and knowledge transfer initiatives to gradually reduce the dependence on expatriate labor.

CONCLUSION

The impact of people's cultural and social perceptions and their knowledge on national participation in the Circular Economy (CE) jobs was 'evaluated' in this research across six countries. Social perception and awareness levels that are favorable and high proved to be the major factors that pulled nationals towards CE sectors while negative social perception led to the dependency on foreign workers to a larger extent. The regression analysis found strong statistical relationships that upheld all three hypotheses, with perception being the strongest predictor of all the influencers. The results point at the need for cultural acceptance, public awareness, and workforce development strategies in the process of national participation in CE industries. It is important to change people's perception, to promote CE job value, and to provide education and skills training in order to achieve the goal of sustainable labor transition and less reliance on expatriates. The research adds to the regional initiatives aimed at the circular economic transformation and also outlines the future directions of policy development.

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